

Competition Details

NSF X-Labs Initiative

Dates

Internal Submission Deadline:	Monday, June 15, 2026
Sensing and Imaging Submission Deadline:	Monday, July 13, 2026 at 2:00 PM
Quantum Systems Submission Deadline:	Friday, July 24, 2026 at 2:00 PM

Details

Administrator(s):	UCSD Limited Submissions (Owner)
Category:	Pre-application
Cycle:	2026-2027
Number of Applications Allowed per Applicant:	1
Number of Possible Awardees:	4
Funding Organization:	U.S. National Science Foundation
Institutional Limit:	An eligible organization can submit a maximum of two Written Proposals per Topic Announcement for Phase 0 as a lead organization.
Program Website:	https://www.nsf.gov/funding/initiatives/nsf-x-labs
Sponsor Reference Number:	NSF-OTASO-FY26-XLabsInitiative
Amount Note:	Phase 0 projects will be awarded up to \$1.5M for 9-12 months. Selected Phase 1 projects will be awarded up to \$50M/year for 2-3 years.

Description

NSF X-Labs is a new initiative designed to build and accelerate novel platform technologies capable of unlocking entirely new sectors, including new fields of scientific inquiry. The program will support full-time research and development (R&D) teams focused on use-inspired scientific breakthroughs and foundational platform technologies that traditional university and industry labs cannot easily address.

NSF seeks applications from teams for the following two initial topics:

- [Scientific Instrumentation for Sensing and Imaging](#)
- [Quantum Systems: Interconnects and Integrated Photonics](#)

Please note that during the Phase 0 review process, NSF will evaluate the extent to which the team's planned operating structure by Phase 1 will reflect the autonomy and flexibility required by the NSF X-Labs initiative. After a 9-12 month Phase 0 period, NSF will engage in a Phase 1 Go/No Go selection process and assess the extent to which the proposed legal and organizational structure is appropriate for the proposed work and will use the Autonomy Factor Test (described in sections 6.1 and 6.1.1. of [NSF-OTASO-FY26-XLabsInitiative](#) solicitation) to evaluate the extent to which the team structure reflects the autonomy and flexibility expected of the NSF X-Labs initiative. **UC San Diego will strongly consider team plans for meeting the Autonomy Factor Test by Phase 1 during the internal review process.**

Resources

A list of upcoming [webinars and previous webinar recordings](#) is available on the [program webpage](#).

Internal Pre-application Requirements

Please submit the following materials through ucsd.infoready4.com by the internal deadline:

1. Online Application Form

2. Abbreviated Project Description Upload (2-3 Pages):

- Provide a summary of the project description as described in the Written Proposal Content instructions in section 10.1 of the [NSF-OTASO-FY26-XLabsInitiative](#) solicitation, which includes the following sections:
 - Mission
 - Technology Landscape
 - Outcomes
 - Team Qualifications and Capabilities
 - Note: Per the OTASO, this section should describe the team's intended governance structure and autonomy during Phase 0 and Phase 1 in this section.

3. Senior/Key Personnel List Upload

- List the full names and institutional affiliations for all Co-PIs, Senior/Key Personnel, and partnering organizations.

4. Biosketch for the lead PI Only

Internal Competition Process

Please note that the InfoReady Review system will accept applications until 11:59 PM on the day of the deadline; however, Limited Submission administrators are only available to answer questions and address technical issues via email until 5:00 PM. Thus, applicants are strongly advised to submit before 5:00 PM. If an applicant encounters technical difficulties or questions after business hours, they should email Limited Submissions before the application deadline (11:59 PM) to ensure their timely effort to submit an application is documented.

Should more than the allowable number of pre-applications be received at the internal deadline, a faculty review committee will use the sponsor's review criteria to evaluate all pre-application materials and recommend to the Vice Chancellor for Research and Innovation (VCRI) the most competitive proposals to represent UC San Diego. Internal review committees are comprised of UCSD faculty broadly representing the disciplines and research areas relevant to the sponsor's program.

If selected, PIs should be prepared to complete a full application pursuant to the sponsor's guidelines. If they decide they cannot submit, they are required to notify Limited Submissions as soon as possible, to afford an alternate applicant time to prepare a submission.

Contact

If you have questions about this funding opportunity, please contact the sponsor's program officer. If you have questions about or problems with the InfoReady application portal, please contact [Limited Submissions](#). *NOTE: Most of the time, technical problems can be solved by using a different browser, updating your browser, and/or clearing your cache and browsing history.*